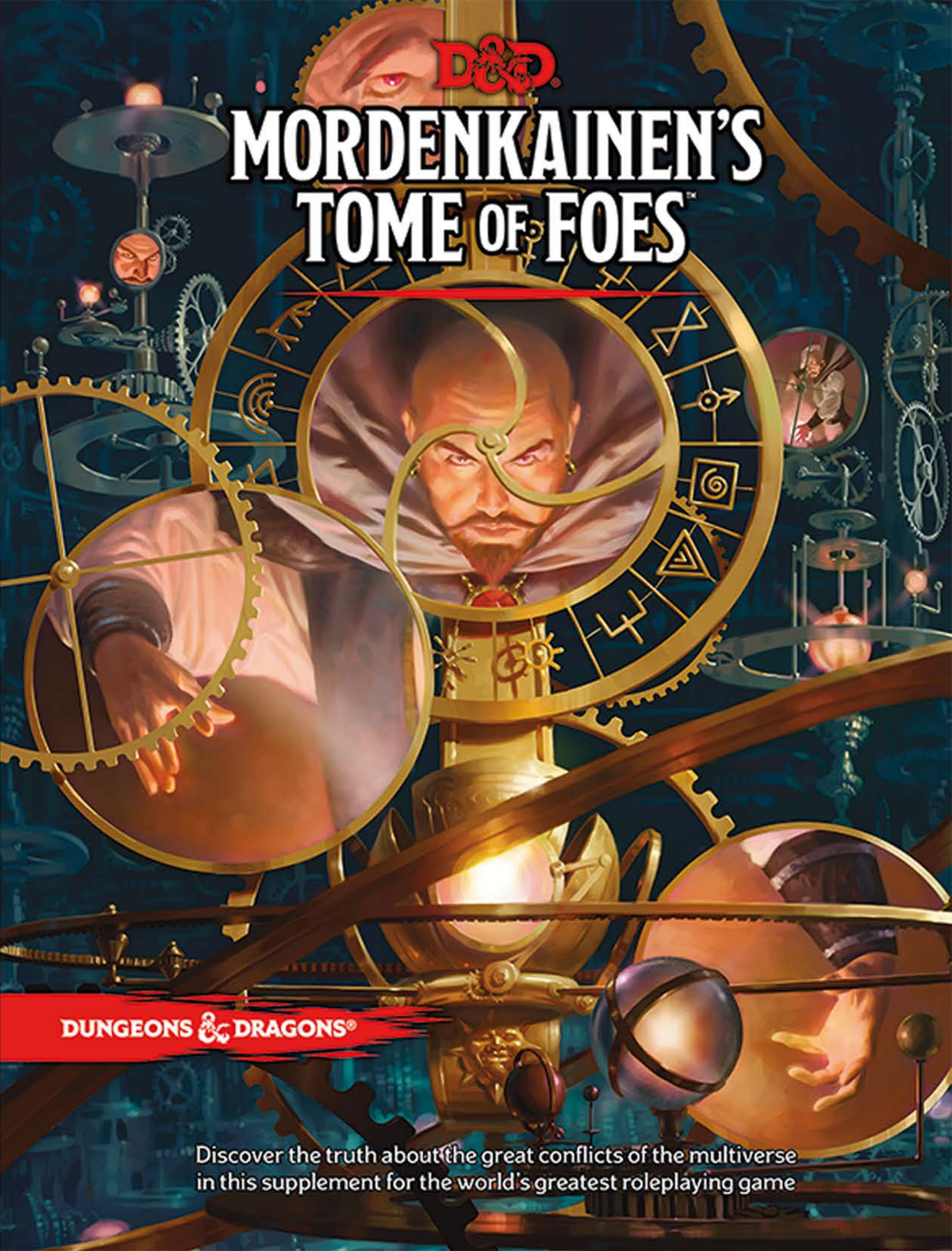
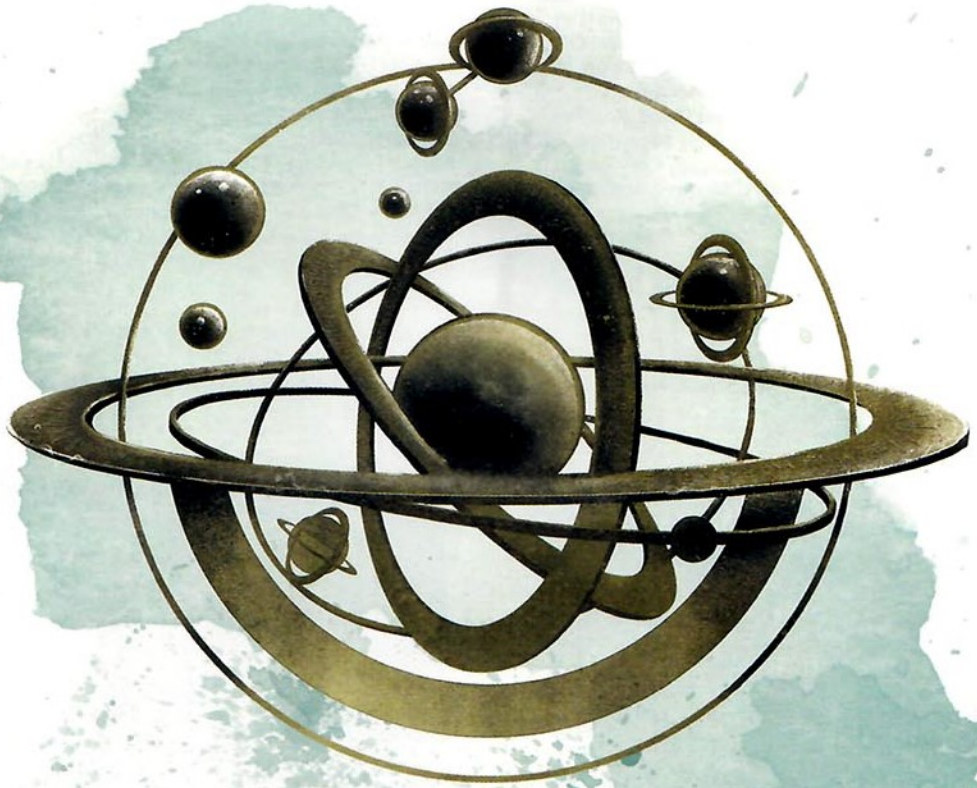

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This book is dedicated to artist William O'Connor, who passed away during its creation. Since 2001, his work has graced numerous D&D products, including this one. Like his art, his was a spirit of vibrancy and warmth.



ON THE COVER

Using an intricate orrery, the wizard Mordenkainen observes conflicts across the D&D multiverse, in this painting by Jason Rainville.



ON THE ALTERNATIVE COVER

The sinister shadows of adversaries emerge under the shrewd gaze of the archmage Mordenkainen, illustrated by Vance Kelly.

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Disclaimer: We asked Mordenkainen to write a humorous disclaimer for this book, and we got this response: "The day I start writing frivolous disclaimers for game manuals—particularly one riddled with text stolen from my notes—is the day I retire from wizardry and abandon all self-respect."

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Contents

Preface 4

Ch. 1: The Blood War 5
The Great Dance 5
Lords of the Nine 9
Diabolical Cults 18
Infernal Cambions 21
Tiefling Subraces 21
Devil Customization Tables 23
Princes of the Abyss 24
Lords and Their Thralls 27
Demonic Boons 30
Demonic Cambions 32
Demon Customization Tables 33
Fiendish Cults 34

Ch. 2: Elves 35
A Race Divided 35
The Elven Diaspora 36
Living in Reverie 36
The Elven Outlook 39
Elves and Magic 42
The Seldarine 43
Eladrin and the Feywild 49
Drow 50
The Raven Queen and the Shadar-kai 58
Elf Subraces 61
Elf Tables 63

Ch. 3: Dwarves and Duergar 65
The Deep Roots of War 65
Dwarves 67
Duergar 77
Duergar Characters 81
Dwarf Tables 81
Duergar Tables 83

Ch. 4: Gith and Their Endless War 85
Githyanki 85
Githzerai 93
Gith Characters 96
Gith Tables 97

Ch. 5: Halflings and Gnomes 99
Halflings 99
Halfling Tables 105
Gnomes 106
Deep Gnome Characters 113
Gnome Tables 114

Ch. 6: Bestiary 115

Appendix: Monster Lists 253

Index of Monster Stat Blocks

Abyssal wretch 136
Adult kruthik 212
Adult oblex 218
Air elemental myrmidon 202
Alkilith 130
Allip 116
Amnizu 164
Armanite 131
Astral dreadnought 117
Autumn eladrin 195
Bael 170
Balhannoth 119
Baphomet 143
Berbalang 120
Black abishai 160
Blue abishai 161
Boneclaw 121
Bronze scout 125
Bulezau 131
Cadaver collector 122
Canoloth 247
Choker 123
Corpse flower 127
Deathlock 128
Deathlock mastermind 129
Deathlock wight 129
Demogorgon 144
Derro 158
Derro savant 159
Dhergoloth 248
Dire troll 243
Drow arachnomancer 182
Drow favored consort 183
Drow house captain 184
Drow inquisitor 184
Drow matron mother 186
Drow shadowblade 187
Duergar despot 188
Duergar hammerer 188
Duergar kavalrachni 189
Duergar mind master 189
Duergar screamer 190
Duergar soulblade 190
Duergar stone guard 191
Duergar warlord 192
Duergar xarrorn 193
Dybbuk 132
Earth elemental myrmidon 202
Eidolon 194
Elder oblex 219
Elder tempest 200
Female steeder 238
Fire elemental myrmidon 203
Fraz-Urb'luu 146
Frost salamander 223
Geryon 173
Giff 204
Githyanki gish 205
Githyanki kith'rak 205
Githyanki supreme commander 206
Githzerai anarch 207
Githzerai enlightened 208
Gloom weaver 224
Gray render 209
Graz'zt 149
Green abishai 162
Hellfire engine 165
Howler 210
Hutijin 175
Hydroloth 249
Iron cobra 125
Juiblex 151
Kruthik hive lord 212
Leviathan 198
Male steeder 238
Marut 213
Maurezhi 133
Meazel 214
Merregon 166
Merrenoloth 250
Moloch 177
Molydeus 134
Nabassu 135
Nagpa 215
Narzugon 167
Nightwalker 216
Nupperibo 168
Oaken bolter 126
Oblex spawn 217
Ogre battering ram 220
Ogre bolt launcher 220
Ogre chain brute 221
Ogre howdah 221
Oinoloth 251
Orcus 153
Orthon 169
Phoenix 199
Red abishai 160
Retriever 222
Rot troll 244
Rutterkin 136
Sacred statue 194
Shadow dancer 225
Sibriex 137
Skulk 227
Skull lord 230
Soul monger 226
Spirit troll 244
Spring eladrin 196
Star spawn grue 234
Star spawn hulk 234
Star spawn larva mage 235
Star spawn mangler 236
Star spawn seer 236
Steel predator 239
Stone cursed 240
Stone defender 126
Summer eladrin 196
Sword wraith commander 241
Sword wraith warrior 241
The Angry 231
The Hungry 232
The Lonely 232
The Lost 233
The Wretched 233
Titivilus 179
Tortle 242
Tortle druid 242
Vampiric mist 246
Venom troll 245
Wastrilith 139
Water elemental myrmidon 203
White abishai 163
Winter eladrin 197
Yagnoloth 252
Yeenoghu 155
Young kruthik 211
Zaratan 201
Zariel 180
Zuggtmoy 157

Preface

You have in your hands that which you covet, just as I promised. It is indeed the true work of that Oeridian wizard Mordenkainen, although penned in large part by his apprentice, Bigby. You didn't know that? Yes—the work of two great wizards for the price of one! You should pay me extra.

Bigby wrote as dictated by his master, burdened by the chains of a charm spell. Eventually, Mordenkainen released Bigby from the spell once he had turned Bigby away from his evil ways and Bigby had earned Mordenkainen's trust. The last few chapters are thus in Mordenkainen's own hand. But you'll see the voice of the author is the same throughout.

Funny, isn't it? How all the stories say that Mordenkainen rescued Bigby from evil? Does Mordenkainen seem like the kind of person whose virtues outweigh his villainy? Do you think him capable of saving a soul? Does he seem like someone who'd even care?

Perhaps it's no accident that this book contains Mordenkainen's first expression of the Balance. In here, he starts to describe the multiverse as a collection of opposing forces, each one trying to tip the scales of fate in its favor. He posits that if any side in a struggle grows too powerful, it becomes tyrannical. But where does that leave us—all the soldiers in all these wars? Surely for the soldiers of all sides, a war is better when it is over.

Are you a soldier? What war do you fight? Whose side are you on? Law or Chaos? Evil or Good? Can you be sure that Mordenkainen would judge you as you judge yourself? When he puts his thumb on the scales to preserve the Balance, can you be certain that the weight of that finger will not crush you?

All this might seem odd coming from a yugoloth, but you should believe me, because I am in the best position to know: endless wars profit only mercenaries and arms dealers. Think on this as you peruse the wise words of Mordenkainen.

—The words of Shemeshka the Marauder, upon delivering *Mordenkainen's Tome of Foes*

I've included Shemeshka's words in this copy of my master's seminal work because they have haunted me from the moment she uttered them. I know her kind exists to twist truth and to deceive, and she in particular has a reputation for ruthlessness in pursuit of her ends. But what was her end here?

Am I to believe my tutor and friend Mordenkainen was actually twisted to evil by Bigby? Am I to believe that the ideals of the Circle of Eight are self-serving, merely a way for them to justify murder and plunder?

I cannot do so. Mordenkainen has no need for ever more magic and treasure. He is not a cruel man.

And yet ... I must confess that I paid Shemeshka to purloin the book without Mordenkainen's knowledge. My desire to preserve the works of my master is not one he shares. But this treatise on the conflicts of the multiverse has many important insights, and its value as a historical document—as the birthplace of Mordenkainen's philosophy of the Balance—cannot be overstated.

I hope that once he learns of this small betrayal on my part, Mordenkainen will see that disseminating the results of his scholarship serves his ends. If more people understood his quest, surely his work would be made easier.

—Qort

There are no small betrayals.
—Mordenkainen

About This Book

In the worlds of Dungeons & Dragons, conflicts rage within mortal realms and in the very domains of the gods. This book explores some of the greatest conflicts in the D&D multiverse and delves into the cultures of the peoples and monsters involved in those conflicts. Why do dwarves and duergar hate each other? Why are there so many kinds of elves? What lies at the heart of the Blood War, the great cosmic struggle between demons and devils that threatens to destroy everything if either side were ever to emerge victorious? This book provides answers to those questions and many more.

The first five chapters present material for a Dungeon Master to add depth to a campaign that involves the ongoing conflicts described there. Options for players are provided as well, including new character races.

Chapter 6 contains game statistics for dozens of monsters: new demons and devils, several varieties of elves and duergar, and a vast array of other creatures from throughout the planes of existence. The appendix lets you look up stat blocks in this book by challenge rating, creature type, and environment.

A companion to the *Monster Manual* and *Volo's Guide to Monsters*, this book contains the musings of the renowned wizard Mordenkainen from the world of Greyhawk. In his travels to other worlds and other planes of existence, he has made many friends, and has risked his life an equal number of times, to amass the knowledge contained herein.